The minister of education says that teachers who strike tomorrow will forfeit their salary, while students skipping school will receive a “missing” mark in their file. The principal of one of the major Tel Aviv high schools has encouraged the students to be in Jerusalem tomorrow. Private donors declare that civil servants who lose salary will be reimbursed.

Herzog spoke well and offered some principles that would allow for negotiations between the coalition and its opponents. He had hardly finished when the coalition announced that votes in favor of various aspects of the judicial reform will take place tomorrow morning, as planned. If so, the strike and the Jerusalem demonstrations will also take place, as planned.

The government has authorized nine new outposts and the construction of thousands of new homes within existing settlements in the West Bank. This may increase the tension with the US. Is it a sheer Likud provocation to keep the coalition afloat? Of course, there could be a long interval between the authorization and anything actually happening.

Monday, February 13

Levin and Rotman didn’t postpone the first round of votes on the reform laws, but announced their willingness to meet with Lapid and Gantz in Herzog’s presence as early as tonight to find a compromise. On the face of it, this looks like a retreat. Is it merely clever window-dressing, sheer pretense, or are the two hooligans, and Netanyahu in the background, ready for some concrete talks? The 90,000 demonstrators who marched yesterday in Jerusalem may have incited this untypical readiness for negotiations. Some say that members of the Likud are demanding dialogue. A poll taken yesterday showed that over 60 percent of Israelis are against the judicial reforms.

Knesset member David “Dudi” Amsalem from the Likud, who, after pestering Netanyahu, is supposed to become minister in the Justice